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From the editor-in-chief

In another era, the word 'front' usually applied to battle and the movement of troops but in 21st century India, 'front' has come to represent quite a different phenomenon. In the age of coalition politics in India, "the Front" is merely an euphemism for the alliance (some say of the unholy variety) of regional parties to jockey for power at the Centre during election season.

As national parties like the Congress and BJP have waned in their influence, regional satraps play a key role in government formation around election time. They band together in loose groups depending on their personal equations with the main national parties and each other. The name given to this somewhat insidious bargaining platform is the "Front". At its height the outgoing United Progressive Alliance (UPA) that ran India from 2004 to 2009 was led by the Congress, consisted of 12 other parties and was supported by five more from the outside.

Once again in these elections, neither the Congress nor the BJP are expected to pull in the majority required to form a government on their own. The night of the power brokers approaches and therefore front formation is at full throttle. At the moment no one is sure how many alternative fronts exist and this confusion is understandable. After all, what do J. Jayalalithaa and Mayawati have in common? Lalu Yadav and Mulayam Singh Yadav share nothing apart from a name.

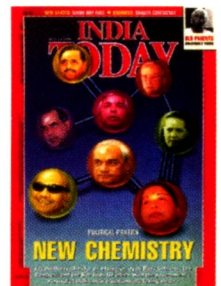
What the parties say before and during the election has little to do with how they act or form alliances once the numbers are in. Their agenda has no ideological moorings other than a single-point programme—to prevent their most bitter political adversaries from ascending to power on Raisina Hill. So the CPI(M) will ally with anyone to keep the BJP out of power. Chandrababu Naidu will join hands with the BJP to stop the Congress from forming the government. "The Front" is an oligarchy created to erode the large political monopolies represented by the Congress and BJP.

Whoever can bring the numbers required on the day can then negotiate for their share of the spoils in the form of key ministries. The influence of small regional players therefore becomes disproportionately large. In the UPA, the DMK with its 16 MPs has controlled all the economic ministries. Sharad Pawar's NCP may have only 11 MPs in the 14th Lok Sabha, but NCP men ran key ministries like agriculture and civil aviation.

This week, we continue our special election series on the leading contenders in the 2009 Lok Sabha polls by focusing on these regional politicians, whom we call the 'Front Runners'. Special Correspondent Shafi Rahman and our nationwide bureaus put together this week's cover story on a disparate cast of characters and their labyrinthine relationships with the national parties and each other.

Come May 16, it is inevitable these ambitious, shrewd and cynical men and women will take centre stage in Delhi again. This is the reality of India's current political landscape but such an arithmetic of expediency and convenience is not the way to find the right people to run the government of a vast, complex country beset with many problems. Looks like we will have to learn our lessons the hard way.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR MAY
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